

Sennheiser HD 300 PRO

For the professionals on the go

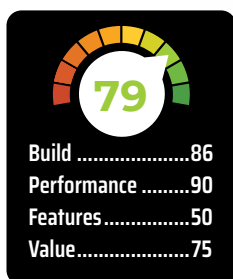
When the Sennheiser HD 300 PRO headphones showed up at the Digit Test Centre, I was curious to see how many boxes they would tick. They are touted to be one of the best that Sennheiser has to offer. So, here's the full account of my experience of using them and how they fared when I put them through our rigorous testing process.

BUILD, DESIGN, AND COMFORT

The build of the Sennheiser HD 300 PRO is completely plastic, but the plastic used is of awesome quality. The headband of these headphones is also made of plastic, which in the beginning did not instil a lot of confidence in me. However, after daily usage, all my inhibitions about the headphones' durability were knocked out of the park. The cable is not swappable. As for the cushioning on the earcups and the headband, the Viscoelastic material used by Sennheiser makes wearing the headphones extremely comfortable. The swivel on the earcups might seem limited at first. But once you start using the headphones, you will know how great it is. One thing that I loved about these headphones is that not only the cushioning on the earcups but also the one present on the headbands is replaceable. Having easily swappable parts, which we know for a fact are going to degrade, is always nice. These headphones have the quintessential studio look, and you would not like to wear them out in public unless you want everyone to know what your hobby is or what profession you practice. Being wired headphones meant for studio use, these do not have any fancy features that we see on consumer-grade headphones.

PERFORMANCE

When it comes to performance, these



headphones are directly competing with their 400 series cousins. I was confused as to why Sennheiser would have two headphones in the same price bracket? The sound signature is pretty neutral for the most part. All the way 20 Hz to 1,000 Hz, the line is parallel to our baseline and benchmark reading of the pink noise. But, as soon as we cross the 1,000 Hz mark, there's a slight dip, followed by a massive spike in the Low to High Treble range. This is a very normal thing in Sennheiser's professional-grade headphones. There also a dip around 1 kHz range, which was there in these headphones as well, but not that significant. Because of the massive boost in frequencies, we get sibilance. If that happens over a prolonged period of time, people tend to experience fatigue with some extreme cases ending with headaches as well. Coming to day to day music listening and content consumption. In songs like Selkies: The Endless Obsession by Between the Buried and Me, all the quintessential metal instruments registered their presence with authority. The bass response was a bit muted, so bass lovers, stay away. These headphones are closed back, which in most cases,

limits the sound stage of the headphones. However, in these headphones, the sound stage could be compared to some open-back headphones out there. Some is the keyword. There is no Active Noise Cancellation on these headphones, but the passive isolation works wonders. Given that the isolation is great, thanks to the fit, the sound leakage is also minimal. Until I cranked the volume up to 50 per cent, there was no leakage. Past the 60 per cent mark, there is a considerable leak. However, I cannot think of any scenario where you'd listen to these headphones past the 25-30 per cent volume mark for extended periods.

VERDICT

So, let's address the question with which I opened the performance section – Why release the HD 300 PRO, when you already have the HD 400 PRO out there? From what I could gauge, they do not target the same audience. The HD 400 PRO have an open-back design, with a higher frequency range, and are meant for professionals working in a closed space. They are not as portable as the 300 PRO and the open-back design leads to lesser isolation and more leaking of audio. With the HD 300 PRO you get a more portable design with a closed-back design which has better isolation and less sound leakage. The only trade-off is the narrower frequency range, but my assumption is that if you are on the go, you are not gunning for perfection. Should you go for it? Yes. If you are a professional working in the music production industry and are always on the go. The headphones sound great, are portable, and have a closed-back design, minimising sound leakage and adding great isolation. However, if you are someone who mostly works out of a studio, then I'd say pay the price difference and go for the Sennheiser HD 400 PRO.

–Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Ear Coupling: Circumaural | Acoustic Principle: Dynamic // Closed | Frequency Response: 6 – 25,000 Hz | Maximum SPL: 123 dB | Impedance: 64 Ω

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